

Protesters Question Trump's Plan for a Huge Arch

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Dozens of people protested at Memorial Circle in Washington, D.C., on Thursday, October 1, 2026. They opposed President Donald Trump's plan for a 250-foot-tall **arch**. It would stand in a traffic circle on the bridge connecting the National Mall to Arlington National Cemetery.

Veterans, retirees and **lawmakers** attended. Speakers questioned the **arch**'s size, cost and location. They also said Congress had not approved it. They stood beside a tarp model they said was much smaller than the planned **arch**.

Jon Gundersen, a retired Army veteran and former Foreign Service officer, came from South Carolina. He is among the Vietnam War **veterans** suing the administration over the project. Public Citizen, the group leading the **lawsuit**, helped organize the protest.

Several speakers wanted **veterans** and their families to have more say. Senator Tammy Duckworth and other opponents said better services for **veterans** would honor them more.

The White House told NPR that the **arch** would improve cemetery visits and remind people of American heroes' sacrifices.

Federal approval is still **pending**. At a Tuesday meeting, administration officials said they would keep the original plan. The National Capital Planning Commission is widely expected to consider it in early November.

A separate review about nearby protected landmarks ended early in the last week of September. The Advisory Council on Historic Preservation said it would send advice directly to Interior Secretary Doug Burgum by October 7. Charles Birnbaum of The Cultural Landscape Foundation criticized ending talks after only two meetings.

Some protesters want Congress to block **federal funding**. A Republican senator blocked a Democratic attempt earlier that week. November's midterm elections could change control of Congress and affect the project starting in January. The **lawsuit** continues.

Word Treasure

arch -- A structure with a curved top and an opening underneath.

veterans -- People who have served in the military.

lawmakers -- People whose work includes making laws.

lawsuit -- A disagreement brought to a court for a legal decision.

federal funding -- Money provided by the national government.

pending -- Still waiting for a decision or action.

Break it down

The opening gives the protest's date, place and reason, then describes the planned arch.

The next paragraphs explain protesters' concerns and introduce the lawsuit.

The article presents opponents' preferred way to honor veterans and the White House's view.

The final paragraphs explain the remaining approval steps and possible effects of Congress and elections.

Why it matters

The proposal raises questions about how to honor veterans, use government money and make decisions near protected landmarks. Its future remains uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. How tall would the planned arch be?

- ☐ (A) Two feet
- ☐ (B) October 7
- ☐ (C) 25 feet
- ☐ (D) 250 feet

2. Where did people gather to protest?

- ☐ (A) At Memorial Circle in Washington, D.C.
- ☐ (B) At a meeting in South Carolina
- ☐ (C) Inside the White House
- ☐ (D) Inside Congress

3. Which group helped organize the protest?

- ☐ (A) Public Citizen
- ☐ (B) The National Capital Planning Commission
- ☐ (C) The White House
- ☐ (D) The Advisory Council on Historic Preservation

4. What did Senator Tammy Duckworth and other opponents say would better honor veterans?

- ☐ (A) More traffic circles
- ☐ (B) Ending talks after two meetings
- ☐ (C) A smaller tarp model
- ☐ (D) Better services for veterans

5. What did the White House say the arch would do?

- ☐ (A) Stop the midterm elections
- ☐ (B) Improve cemetery visits and remind people of American heroes' sacrifices
- ☐ (C) End the lawsuit immediately
- ☐ (D) Move the cemetery to South Carolina

6. What is the project's approval status?

- ☐ (A) All reviews have approved the plan.
- ☐ (B) The arch has already been built.
- ☐ (C) Congress has canceled the project.
- ☐ (D) Federal approval is still pending.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

- 1. Protest speakers:** They questioned the arch's size, cost, location and lack of congressional approval. Several wanted veterans and their families to have more say.
- 2. Senator Tammy Duckworth and other opponents:** They said better services for veterans would be a better way to honor them.
- 3. The White House:** It told NPR that the arch would improve cemetery visits and remind people of American heroes' sacrifices.
- 4. Charles Birnbaum:** He criticized the decision to end the protected-landmark discussions after only two meetings.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):